

OnePlus Nord Buds 2r

Simplistic value-for-money earbuds

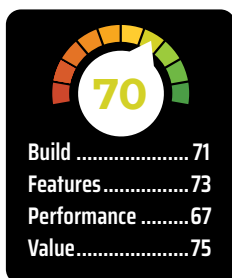
OnePlus has been on a roll with its audio device portfolio. The company launched its premium TWS offering – the OnePlus Buds Pro 2 – and a few budget options including the much-awaited OnePlus Nord Buds 2 this year. All of these were pretty well-received by reviewers as well as consumers. Enter the OnePlus Nord Buds 2r, the younger sibling of the popular OnePlus Nord Buds 2 that sacrifice a feature or two in favour of a more affordable price tag. The OnePlus Nord Buds 2r is priced competitively at ₹2,199 and misses out on Active Noise Cancellation which you get on the OnePlus Nord Buds 2. Do note that the Nord Buds 2 are just priced at just ₹900 more. So, are the Nord Buds 2r good enough to justify missing out on ANC for a few hundred bucks? Let's find out that and more in my detailed review.

DESIGN AND FIT

The OnePlus Nord Buds 2r's design is very reminiscent of the OnePlus Nord Buds 2. The charging case, in particular, is strikingly similar when it comes to shape and size. The earbuds are available in two colourways – Deep Grey and Triple Blue. We got the former for review and it looks pretty 'Plain Jane', but still classy in a minimalist sort of way.

There's some subtle OnePlus branding on the top of the case and a USB-C charging port on the back. You also get an LED indicator on the front that lets you know the pairing and charging status. Upon opening the case, you see both buds tucked into their slots marked L and R, which is pretty convenient (and not always a given).

The earbuds, however, have some new design flourishes. For instance, the edges are far more rounded than



the OnePlus Nord Buds 2 and the OG Nord Buds. It gives them a far better, streamlined look. The touch panels on the back of each bud are indicated with a subtle circular indent. The earphones are also extremely lightweight at just 4.3 g each.

Being lightweight, these are comfortable to wear for long periods of time, but the fit can to be improved. No matter which ear tip I tried, I couldn't get a tight and secure seal which led to inadequate passive isolation and the trouble of having to readjust the buds every few minutes. Your experience could differ, so we suggest you try these out at a store to see if you can find a perfect fit.

Especially since these could make for really solid gym or fitness earbuds with their IP55 dust and water resistance. Overall, I like the understated look but wish the fit was a bit more reassuring.

FEATURES

At ₹2,199, the OnePlus Nord Buds 2r is naturally not the most feature-laden pair of TWS earphones in the market.

In a sense, they are overshadowed by the Nord Buds 2 that launched a couple of months ago since those came with ANC – an all-important feature that many desire.

The buds do come packing app support though – OnePlus users can leverage this in their system's settings while other Android users need to download the HeyMelody app. Sadly, these buds are not supported on the iOS version of the HeyMelody app. So, iPhone users, you would be missing out on some vital customisation opportunities.

The HeyMelody app isn't packed with features, but the ones it does have are well-implemented. There's basic stuff like checking the battery status of your earbuds and performing firmware updates. You've also got the ability to customise your earbud controls – a much-appreciated feature at this price point.

You can customise the single tap, double tap, triple tap, and long press actions on both buds according to your preferences. However, single tap only cycles between 'Play/Pause' and 'None', which is a wasted opportunity. Yet again, we have no volume controls similar to the OnePlus Nord Buds 2. This is disappointing since users would have to pull their devices out every time they wanted to tweak the volume levels.

The app also lets you customise your sound with an inbuilt 6-band EQ – which is fantastic since sometimes even premium earphones only have a 3-4 band EQ. There are also three EQ presets – Balanced (turned on by default), Bass, and Bold. We found the Balanced EQ preset to be the best among all. You can also toggle on and off Game Mode via the app which drops the latency down to 94 ms.

The buds are powered by the latest Bluetooth v5.3 and I found the connectivity to be fantastic. The range is great as well and it even permeates a wall or two with ease. OnePlus users get Fast Pairing which grants them near-instantaneous pairing with their phone. There's also Mono mode support where you can use a single earbud indepen-